President Karmal said the issue should be resolved within the context of the proposed political settlement and moreover, it would depend on the effective guarantees.

According to Reddy, this statement had had the prior approval of the Soviet leadership and it was obvious that they were in no mood to leave. Just before the announcement of the withdrawal of troops, fresh Soviet troops and equipment came into the country and therefore there was no net reduction of Soviet forces in Afghanistan. The withdrawal and its announcement was thus a military move camouflaged as a political settlement of the Afghan crisis. Afghan officials commented that it was now for Pakistan, Iran and the West in general to react to the announcement.

In an attempt to seal the border against infiltration from Pakistan, Soviet troops in the mid 1980s launched a major operation in Paktia province. India's concerns related to Afghanistan were manifold but at least two issues agitated the spies: the training of mujahideen that could be used by Pakistan against India and the unhindered arms supply by the US to the Pakistan army, which was virtually part of its intelligence unit, the ISI.

Zia and the USA Nexus

Pakistani dictator Zia-ul-Haq, who supported the USA's arms supply to Afghan mujahedeen, met Soviet ambassador Vitaly S. Smirnov in Islamabad on 1 January 1981. The two of them sent a letter to the United Nations (UN) asking for the nomination of a special emissary to conduct a dialogue on the Afghanistan issue. India believed that this move was a smokescreen: there were some differences between Pakistan and the Soviet Union, especially on Pakistan's insistence on a trilateral framework